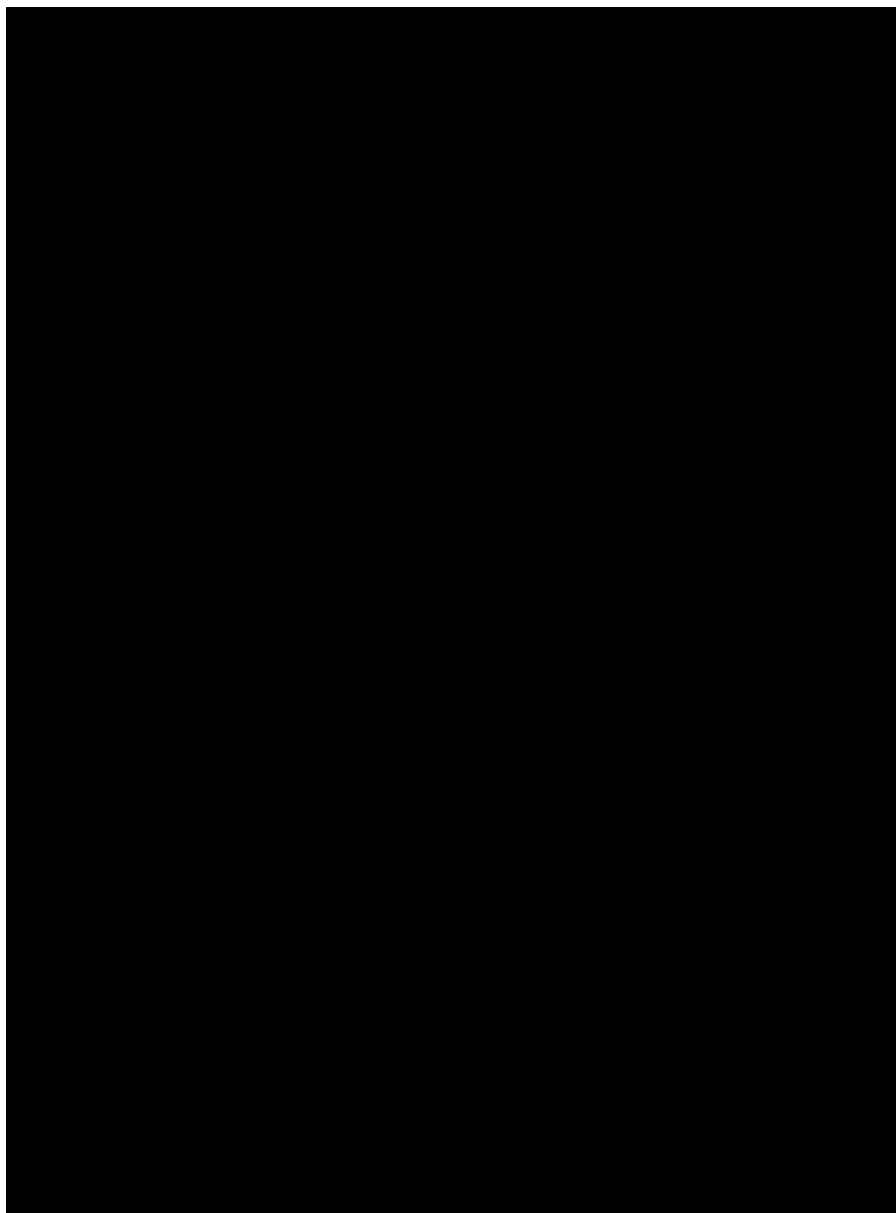




Chapter 4: 1945-56

My mother remarries

After the war, the inevitable happened and my parents divorced again, although they stayed friends. Our apartment house on Ferenc Kőrut was expropriated by the communist regime and we did not receive any compensation so we had to move into a much smaller space in Rákóczi Street.

My mother had several opportunities to remarry. The marriage brokers or arrangers worked overtime to persuade her to marry again, but she would not even consider it.

The choices consisted mostly of men in their late 40s with a past, either widowed or divorced with children. She did not want to go into slavery and look after other people's offspring. She was a woman of independent means and had enough trouble bringing me up.

And then a seemingly more attractive proposition came up. János Schäfer, then in his early 40s, had no previous marital history; he had been a bit of a playboy up to that point. His father was a distinguished lawyer, very intellectual and witty who was the chairman of the lawyers' union. His younger brother was a professor of criminology, well known even in the West for his research into juvenile crime and delinquency.

János was quite handsome, good at maths, but not academic, nor brilliant like his father or brother. He remained a bit of a mother's boy. I was taken to meet his family and was impressed by the wit and integrity of the father, an excellent lawyer president of the Law Society and his younger brother. The mother dressed in black as always, served tea and stayed in the background, not showing her hand for the time being.

Janos worked in a minor administrative position in a bank, which to communist logic was equivalent of being an enemy of the working classes, so he was constantly spied upon and harassed by government informers. I did not take to him, but admitted, rather reluctantly, that my mother, being divorced, needed the love and companionship of a person, nearer to her own age. She took Janos in hand as if he were another child and after a new job was found for

Magda, Lala Mama and I at the Rákoczy Street flat 1955



him in an agricultural commune, Magda insisted that he should take professional qualifications in accountancy and later the very difficult and demanding exam of chartered accountancy. She helped him and rehearsed the examination questions with him endlessly until he passed.

Soon after, when he was working under pressure, János would throw the most frightful hysterical fits or temper tantrums; his eyes became bloodshot, the veins on his neck stood out. He would yell and throw things about. He was used to blackmailing his mother in this way since his infancy and invariably she gave in so as not to disturb her husband.

This behaviour obviously did not wash with Magda, who realized, he wanted to go back to mother, back to his infancy.

His work as a bank clerk was considered, in the eyes of the communist regime, a betrayal of the working class and he was declared an enemy of the state and was under constant surveillance. Strings were pulled and he was finally offered an accountancy job in a collective farm.

Whereas the Kulaks, the owners of more than 100 acres of land were persecuted, taken to labour camps or even killed, collective Kolkhoz type farming was forced onto the peasant or smallholder population by the state, with five year plans and prescribed productivity. The land reform did not make smallholders better off; they became virtual slaves, who could not leave the collective without serious consequences. If they left, they would have to give up their property and land which was then regarded as state or communal asset. The collective farms had to make a profit to fulfil the five year plan.

János became very popular with his collective, sorting out their financial problems with a bit of creative accounting and being granted all kind of privileges. Free hotel accommodation in a winter resort was pleasant, but most importantly for me, we were offered free membership to a boat club on a little island on the Danube.

My mother, meanwhile, started a weaving business, her large hand loom positioned in the kitchen of our home. She was quite unwilling to go into a conventional nine-to-five office job. She was actually earning good money with this, supplemented by a further income generated by translating technical texts from Russian. Her knowledge of Serbian came in useful as did her ability to speak other languages.

My father post-war

In the meantime, my father also married again, rather reluctantly. He had an affair with a beautiful but tragic woman, whose parents and young husband perished in the Holocaust. Her uncle and aunt managed to smuggle her to Switzerland with false papers, where she was accepted into a finishing school. Lots of people led double existences under false identities and sometimes got mixed up between them. This was dangerous territory.

Lily did not learn much at this school but at least she was alive. She married my father under false pretences. She moved into his apartment with a chaise longue and a small rococo



My father and Lilly in happier times



XXXXXXX XXXXX XXXXX
 XXXX XXXXX XXXXX XXXXX

wardrobe in an unguarded moment. Of course, it was her uncle and aunt who arranged this, Lily would not have had the wit to do it. However, under the circumstances, it was impossible to send her back and my father married her. He insisted, however, that she should get an education and proper qualification as a laboratory assistant, so that she could support herself if necessary. This took many years. Lily loved clothes and whenever she bought new outfits, she gave her old clothes to me. I therefore ended up with clothes and shoes which were far too sophisticated for my age. I think the magic of their marriage faded almost straight away. My father suspected Lily of infidelity and was rather jealous of her young admirers in her work place.

After the uprising, my father was denounced by a disgruntled nurse, who informed on him to the authorities. He was subjected to abuse by the communist regime. I have found a letter he sent me in 1958 which shows his shock at this treatment. I quote an excerpt here.

Budapest, October 31 1958

My dearest Goti,

I haven't received a letter from you this week, but I am writing to you so that we don't lose touch. My health is a little bit better, but I can hardly bear the series of injustices that afflict me and I must suppose that they are caused by personal vendetta.

I could not tolerate that vile ignominious people should slander me and prevent my freedom of movement, just because I might have been a bit strict with them or did not tolerate their negligence. I am sure that the higher echelons will eventually see my point.

I am still looking for opportunities to mend this situation. I am also curious to have your views on our discussions on aesthetics. Did you take part in other exhibitions? I would like to know how much your pictures have sold for.

Please don't neglect me as these things unnerve me. I am deeply hurt, that things like that happen to me, especially that I have always gone out of my way to be decent to everyone!

Love and kisses,

Daddy

He had a stroke, from which he recovered somewhat, but he knew that another stroke would be fatal. We managed to talk on the telephone a few times, but he never got permission to visit me in England and died from a second stroke in 1960 aged 64.

I was completely devastated as he meant everything to me. I hardly had the force to read the many letters of condolences and other documentation brought to London a couple of years later by a good friend of his. It is only now, after I found them in a secret drawer, that I am able to study them in detail; I am now processing them and using them in my memoirs.

Further education at the Art Lycée

After the war I went back to school; first to a kind of grammar school nearby, run by Christian teachers, who escaped the war. They were extremely professional and everyone achieved high standards. Having missed two years of schooling I was rather behind and had to work very hard. The curriculum was traditional, but I had at least one imaginative teacher, Miss Aranka, who encouraged me to write and to continue with my art work at home as this was not taught at school. After three years, I passed my exams and applied to the Art Lycée, rather similar to my grandmothers' school in Transylvania, where half the time we did practical art work and the other half was spent on academic subjects leading to a Baccalaureate in at least six subjects.

At the Lycée, the intake of students was rather mixed and some had a formal educational background like me, but others, coming from working class or peasant families, relied purely on their own abilities.

One of my classmates was a rather frightening professional boxer with cauliflower ears and not much in between, another was a young prostitute, who was exploited by a gang of unscrupulous gigolos. She was quite bright, but in a rather desperate situation.

Regardless of their background, they still had to pass the exams. Having been schooled by the 'University of Life', they were bored stiff and were uninterested in academic subjects. I started a study group, where I told them juicy stories of Greek mythology mostly borrowed from Robert Graves, which they found amusing, which lead them eventually to reading and research.

Ervin Gabor

This was the time I met my first boyfriend Ervin Gabor. I first met him through a friend when I was skiing in the hills of Buda. He was with another girl, whom he promptly abandoned with some excuse, in order to join me. He was great fun, energetic and not only extremely bright, but educated to a much higher level than myself. He was already in his first year as a medical student and lent me his notes compiled when he was preparing for his



XXXXXXX XXXXX XXXXX
 XXXX XXXXX XXXXX XXXXX

own Baccalaureate. Never before had I encountered such a level of accomplishment and I started studying much harder and making notes of my own, which I gradually memorised. At this time, it was almost impossible for a middle-class girl to get into higher education, especially with a doctor father, who was regarded as a class enemy and a grandmother in Yugoslavia. Tito was regarded in Hungary as a running dog of the imperialists.

I introduced Ervin to my father as I thought they might get on well. Strangely enough, I was not present during this meeting, which took place in my father's surgery behind padded doors. My father was impressed by Ervin's erudition and drive, his sportsmanship and his commitment to medicine, but thought it was far too early for me to make a serious commitment, especially before I had finished my

studies. We went out several times and while I painted, Ervin took photographs of the landscape; he still has one of my sketches from this period.

We had an argument one day when I visited him unexpectedly. I had seen from the street that the light was on in his room and the entrance door to the apartment was ajar as the cleaner must have stepped out for a minute. Rather ominously the feline legs of the chairs turned upside down on a table pointed upwards towards the ceiling, reminiscent of dead animals. I found Ervin in the arms of another woman. I ran away crying, hurt and deeply disappointed. During a later visit, his mother, who always liked me, told me that Ervin was a bit of a womaniser, and though he claimed to be in love with me, he did have affairs with other girls. She suggested that I should leave him if his behaviour bothered me. And so I did.

Strangely enough we stayed in touch. He fled the country after the 1956 uprising with his new girlfriend Thea, a very beautiful and wise woman who later became his wife and mother of his two children. They settled eventually in Canada, where Hungarian

refugees were still welcome. Nevertheless, in spite of all the good will, life was not easy in Canada and Ervin had to pass his medical exams, finishing his doctorate while working full time, helped by his wife who gave up her ambition of becoming a dentist and also worked full time to help the family during this period. I would not have been able to do this as my artistic development and studies were far too important for me.

Remarkably, we are still close friends and I am very grateful to Ervin for his support in writing these memoirs. He was and is the only one who gives medical advice, keeps sending me information, reads my writing with a critical eye, and asks for updates if he has not heard from me for a while. After all these years I only just learnt that his mother had perished in the Lockerbie air disaster²⁶, which came as a total shock.

The Academy of Applied Arts, Budapest

I realised, that I only had a chance of getting into the Academy of Fine Arts if I achieved the highest marks in everything. By then it was almost impossible to get into higher education for a middle-class girl. Members of the intelligentsia, even doctors were regarded with suspicion as being class enemies and in addition, I had grandparents in Yugoslavia under Tito, who was regarded by the regime as a running dog of the imperialists.

I had to work extra hard to have the slightest chance of a higher education. Although I passed the Baccalaureate with flying colours, I did not get into the Academy of Fine Arts, but only secured a place at the Academy of Applied Arts. I was really disappointed as I did not think it was not on the same level and had few really good artists on its staff.

Nevertheless, I learnt a few very useful techniques in my time there, including stained glass, technical drawing and the historic mural technique, sgraffito. This involves using two layers of plaster, the top one is cut into like a woodcut. The result mimics Greek vases on a grand scale.

I also met students of a higher grade, which included a future heartthrob and my future husband.

I started on a large stained-glass window held together using several layers of bitumen instead of lead. The wonderful coloured glass came from Murano in Italy and was the property of one of our

²⁶ On 21 December 1988, Pan Am flight 103, flying from London to New York, was destroyed by a bomb, killing all 243 passengers and 16 crew as well as 11 people on the ground

tutors who demonstrated this new technique to me.

I was given a narrow but long store room and I locked the door whenever I started working there. As I could not see the piece in its entirety I had to climb up on top of a cupboard and look at my construction using Lala Mama's theatre glasses in reverse.

Unfortunately, a cleaner got hold of the key to my storeroom and when she moved it, she smashed my creation into smithereens.

It was a blow as I had put in several months' work. Nevertheless, the interest in large scale transparent structures stayed with me, but I realised that any future work in similar media would have to be tough and unbreakable. The idea stayed dormant at the back of my mind until several years later, during a visit to Philadelphia, where I met a plastics manufacturer, Charlie Kanev²⁷, who gave me materials and showed me how to work with acrylics. And so, the idea of *Space Engravings*, which was so important in my development, began to take shape.

There was one more noteworthy incident, while I was at the Academy of Applied Arts. I went out painting in the nearby woods, hardly noticing the rather nondescript white building behind with a watch tower located behind a barbed wire fence. I had my back to it in any case and I must have been a good 200 metres away. I started painting some trees, but I had only made a few marks, when I was arrested by AVO officers, who asked for identification and as I did not have any on me, wanted to take me to the dreaded AVO²⁸ headquarters in Andrásy út. I managed somehow to persuade them to take me to back to the Academy, where the director told them that I was indeed a student and I was working on a project. The Academy had to assure them that this would never happen again and that students would keep well away from the barracks in future. My husband told me recently, that Rákosi's wife was studying pottery at the Academy at the time and that it was she who in fact engineered my release.

27 See Volume 2, Part 8, Chapter 7

28 The AVO (Államvédelmi Osztály) was the notorious and State Security Agency, a much hated and feared secret police, modelled on the Soviet KGB and their officers were even trained by them. They were famous for their brutality; having operated totally outside the law they relied on a network of informants. They tortured, murdered, executed, arranged kidnappings and show trials, extracted confessions and disposed of their victims in hydrochloric acid. They were one of the main causes of the 1956 uprising

29 The Austrian Herbert von Karajan (1908-1989) was principal conductor of the Berlin Philharmonic Orchestra for 35 years



Herbert von Karajan in
concert

There was another rather more cheerful incident which could have landed me in trouble. It had become a bit of a sport among students to try to get into plays or concerts free of charge. The venue I wanted to attend was being in the Zoo where the renowned conductor Herbert von Karajan²⁹ would be appearing. He liked coming to Hungary as he had a great rapport with the musicians.

I waited until they closed the zoo and climbed up to the roof structure of a burnt-out reptile house, where all the glass was broken and missing. It was a precarious position, but I enjoyed a magnificent view of the stage and the orchestra with the park in the background.

Unfortunately, the audience noticed me. Karajan stopped the concert and looked up. Searchlights swept the structure and security guards were sent up to get me down. I was absolutely terrified and thought that at the very least I was going to be thrown out unceremoniously or taken to the AVO Headquarters for questioning.

When they got me down, I had a great surprise; Karajan set me down in the first row, which was empty at the time and then continued with the concert.

With the swarm of journalists trying to interview him and people asking for autographs after the concert I did not even have the chance to thank him properly.



Work by Robert Berény and Sándor Bortnyik from the Műhely, 1928-1938 they were closely associated with Laszlo Moholy-Nagy and the Bauhaus throughout this period

Studies at the Academy of Fine Arts

In 1954, at long last, I heard that I was able to transfer to the Academy of Fine Arts.

I was overjoyed. The Director was Sándor Bortnyik³⁰ who had been involved with the Bauhaus and the head of my college was Róbert Berény³¹.

Several very well-known artists led the studios, like Aurél Bernáth³², and Bertalan Pór³³ or the famous Anatomist and cubist painter Jenő Barcsay³⁴. The problem was that they were not allowed to work freely and in the style in which they excelled. They were forced to adapt and teach social realism³⁵, depicting brave featureless manual workers and peasants charging forward, conceived in garish colours and without black outlines as the

30 Sándor Bortnyik (1893-1976) was a Hungarian painter and graphic designer. He was director of the Hungarian Academy of Fine Arts from 1949 until 1956. He is most famous for his designs for Modiano cigarette papers

31 Róbert Berény (1887-1953) was a Hungarian painter. He was a member of one of the avant-garde group known as *The Eight* who introduced cubism, expressionism and fauvism to Hungarian art in the early twentieth century

31 Aurél Bernáth (1895-1982) was a Hungarian painter and art theorist whose early work was influenced by German Expressionism

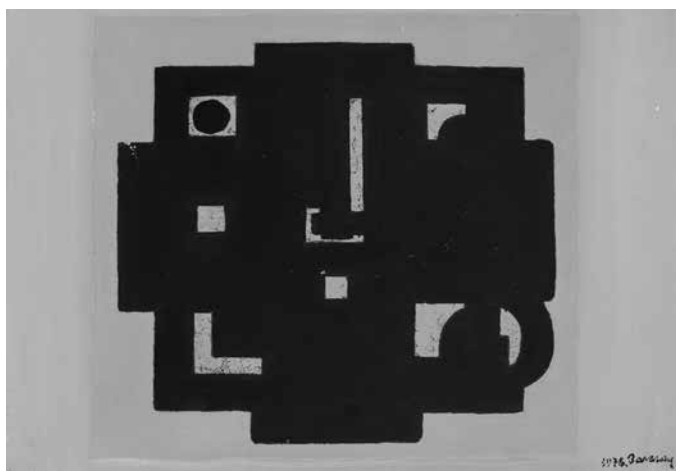
32 Bertalan Pór (1880-1964) was a Hungarian painter associated with the development of modernist Hungarian art who represented the radical edge in Budapest

34 Jenő Barcsay (1900-1988) had travelled both in Italy, where he gained a knowledge of life drawing, and in Paris where he was influenced by Cubism. He taught sketching and anatomy.

35 Socialist Realism was the official art style promoted by the Soviet Union and other Communist countries which glorified Communist values



Barcsay's abstract paintings were banned by the communist regime and were never seen by the public in spite of his book of Anatomy which was a worldwide success



outlines might suggest a pessimistic mood. These rules were enforced by the Communist Party, based on the Soviet official style. The Academy was located directly opposite the notorious building of the AVO which loomed over us.

Work by Robert Berény and Sandor Bortnyik from the Műhely 1928-1938 were closely associated with Laszlo Moholy –Nagy and the Bauhaus throughout this period.

Barcsay's abstract paintings were banned by the communist regime and were never seen by the public in spite of his book of Anatomy which was a worldwide success.



Margit Graber

We all knew that they were spying on us and unspeakable acts of brutality, torture and executions were taking place in that building, a few yards from our studios. It was quite a relief that I was sent to the studio of Bertalan Pór, which was around 500 meters down a side road in a gracious villa with a large garden called Strawberry Fields. There we were allowed to draw from live nude models in the poses we chose without interference. It was heaven! Once a week we went over to the main building for our anatomy lesson.

First, we made detailed drawings of particular bones, taking into account their structure and function, then we placed those bones into context as being part of an arm or leg; in the end, we drew the whole skeleton in movement, having positioned a live model next to it. This was followed by the study of the musculature, again with a model in close proximity.

We were also sent to a hospital to see the dissection of corpses, which had been previously soaked in formaldehyde and seemed almost mummified. It was very gratifying that Barcsay liked my work and singled me out as an exceptional candidate.

In the meantime, my father managed to get me work experience with a few distinguished artists in their studios: One was Kisfaludy Stroble Zsigmond, a famous sculptor who learnt bronze casting in Rodin's studio in Paris, and who later made the Sculpture of Liberty. He also entered the competition for the Stalin Sculpture erected in 1951 on the occasion of Stalin's 70th birthday³⁶. The scale models were in his studio when I was there, although the competition was finally won by Mikus Sándor.

I also enjoyed and valued the company of Margit Graber³⁷, a distinguished Post-Impressionist painter and Margit Kovacs³⁸, an extraordinarily innovative potter, whose sculpture and figurines were created in clay on the wheel. I had a little table or easel in their studio, where I could do my own work or be instructed by technicians in the techniques used by these masters.

The long life drawing classes in Strawberry Fields studios began to bore me, so I joined an evening class which was run privately nearby where they had young models stand in quick natural poses. It was great fun and I started to experiment with watercolour in my sketches.

³⁶ Kisfaludy Stroble Zsigmond (1884-1975) was a sculptor whose monumental work can be found throughout Hungary

³⁷ Margit Graber (1895-1993) distinguished post-impressionist painter one of the few Hungarian artists still listed in the West

³⁸ The work of Margit Kovacs (1902-1977) can be seen at the museum that bears her name in Szentendre



Agathe with her mentor, the famous anatomist, Jeno Barcsay. In the background there are some of his known drawings and an original pen drawing by another mentor, the post-impressionist painter Margit Graber. Both lived in the artist colony of Szentendre.

There, I seemed to have inspired an older painter who was already quite successful in selling his work, but felt that he lacked something important. He must have been in his mid-30s. He had a motorbike, and suggested that we should go out and paint in the countryside. I sat in the back, holding onto two canvases and a bag of watercolours. We went to a small lake, which was slightly misty, rather Japanese in feeling. I must say he behaved as a perfect gentleman and did not proposition me, we just painted.

My father got very worried and took me to his hospital to show me a department full of motorcycle casualties. It was horrible to see and to contemplate the waste of young lives. He made me promise not to get onto a motorcycle or scooter ever again. I kept to this promise although later on it cost me a relationship or maybe even marriage to a well-known painter and outstanding intellectual, who was teaching at Camberwell at the time.

Somewhat disappointed, the painter took another girl from my class. He died very young a few years later not from a motor cycle accident but from a heart attack after drinking heavily in the staff room. I do not think his marriage worked out.

Mosquito Island

Mosquito Island is on the Danube north of Budapest is linked to the mainland by a narrow bridge.

This almost uninhabited and totally unspoilt island was like a rain forest with tall trees and brambles.

The island was a great inspiration to me. I took some friends there and showed them around in a variety of rowing boats or dinghies.

There were only two buildings there, a big hangar for the boats and a small house for David, the boathouse keeper, who had the house rent free and received a small salary for doing very little indeed. He did not know or care about boats, although sometimes he reluctantly gave me a hand to lower a boat into the water. He was an Egyptologist and he had a real Egyptian mummy and several mummified animals and other artefacts in this tiny house. He was busy analysing and restoring them and translated the ancient hieroglyphs, which decorated the mummy on several levels, from the outer case to the bandages. The history, domestic and social customs, religious beliefs and even poetry were all there to be deciphered.

This was an ideal job for a recluse and I learnt a lot from him.

When my mother came with my stepfather, she chose a light boat, mostly a skip and balanced it over her head with one hand

and took it down to the water all by herself.

I usually needed help to take a dinghy to the jetty and sometimes terrified my guests as I was able to stand up and move about this little craft to get to my painting gear or camera.

A guest, who became a well-known art historian was totally traumatised by this and also by the fleet of ducks which followed us, diving into the water with only their tails sticking out above the surface as they were fishing. This chap later settled in England never spoke to me again, but later became the Queen's curator and advisor on her art collections.

A trip to the island was one of my mother's last excursions in Hungary as she contracted Hepatitis and was terribly ill for several weeks. I painted her with frighteningly yellow complexion amid white sheets. I still think of it as one of my best works.

2 cellos Dubrovnik festival <https://youtu.be/DcFpvolRN3w>

Dubrovnik festival with Cusi fan tutte <https://youtu.be/WcbEPp7EWCM>

Dalmatia

When Stalin died, there was a brief period, when Khrushchev and Gorbachev denounced the brazen personality cult of their leader, when Tito was no longer regarded as the running dog of the imperialists and it was possible to get a visa for study purposes to go to Yugoslavia.

I managed to spend a few days with Lala Mama in Vrbas. I then took the train to Trieste and I was waiting to get a boat, which was the best way to visit the islands and the historic cities of the Dalmatian coast. I took my watercolours and sketchbooks, a swimsuit and not much else. It was summer. I had been waiting for a few hours, when a small cargo boat pulled up at the quay, which was willing to take on passengers for a small fee. As it happened, I was the only customer after a few stops and the marvellously handsome captain took me to some of the islands and to Split and Dubrovnik, showing me the ancient fortifications, churches, monasteries, palaces and fountains. After all our sightseeing, the captain confessed, that he was not hours but several days late, and took his leave. He behaved as a perfect guide and gentleman, although his breakfast of raw onions, bacon and wine was a bit off-putting.

In Dubrovnik, one could see all the architectural styles; Gothic, Renaissance and Baroque buildings concentrated into one small area. At the nightly opera performances, they did not bother with sets; they just pushed the stage, orchestra pit and auditorium around in the streets and asked the audience and the orchestra to

follow. I could not imagine a more exciting and romantic setting for *Hamlet*, *La Traviata* or *The Masked Ball* and greatly enjoyed seeing the characters from the opera high up in the ancient fortifications singing in full moonlight. The firing of canons shook the earth and gave the performances even more reality.

The Veszprém Library

Another memorable experience was my trip to Veszprém during one of our summer camps, where we were encouraged to paint and draw out of doors in the landscape. I took a commercial boat with a small outboard motor from one side of Lake Balaton to the little cove nearest to Veszprém, a beautiful historic town with one of the oldest and most famous libraries of codices, painted scrolls and early books. The station was quite a way from town, so I hitched a lift on a donkey cart delivering wine to the city.

As I sat with the driver, my painting gear and watercolours were placed at the back of the open cart. The clouds darkened and a terrible wind scattered all my watercolours down a hill and into a ravine. There was not a hope in hell that I could retrieve them. It was just too dangerous and would have been futile.

A very kind woman from the village who was walking down the same road volunteered to collect them and although I told the driver that I needed them and that I was going to the famous library run by priests in the well known historic building, he was not interested as he had to deliver his barrels in daylight. So we proceeded as fast as the donkey would trot, which was pretty slow.

Upon arriving at the building of classical beauty, through some divine intervention, a priest in black habit stood on the doorstep with all my watercolours in hand, waiting for me. A man with a horse-drawn carriage had brought them in.

The priest then took me to the Holy of Holies, the famous library, which is not open to the public and, after putting on white cotton gloves, showed me its treasures. The marvellous paintings with gesso inlays and gold were all hand painted and were unique historic pieces. They rarely saw the light of day to avoid deterioration. I made a mental note of the use of gold and stacked it away in my memory to be later used in my *livre d'artiste Le Balcon*³⁹.

The collection he showed me formed part of the famous Bibliotheca Corvinaria, assembled by King Matthias Corvinus (1453-1490) which was the largest library in Europe north of the

³⁹ See Volume 2 for further details



Alps and one of the most famous of the Renaissance era.

Matthias, or Mátyás Király in Hungarian was only 14 years old when he was elected King following the execution of his elder brother which almost caused a civil war. He was already an accomplished linguist and spoke many languages including Latin and Greek. He was a Humanist scholar who commissioned the creation of many books dealing not only with religious themes, but with science, architecture and history. These works were added to when he married Beatrice of Aragon in 1476 who brought with her many more as a dowry. These manuscripts were commissioned from and executed by the best artists and scribes of the day at various workshops in Hungary, Italy and Vienna. It was calculated to comprise around 2500 codices, most of which were housed in the Zirc library, north of Veszprém. The libraries themselves were also architectural gems.

The library was broken up following the Hungarian defeat to the Ottomans in 1526. Some volumes were given as presents to visiting dignitaries and therefore survived the Ottoman conquest and its deliberate and devastating destruction of the cultural heritage in Hungary. Hungary's National Széchényi Library, which holds 35 of the original Corvinus manuscripts, is working on projects to restore the Corvina library in digital form.

Left: Bibliotheca Corviniana - Cod. Lat. 417 - Philostratus: Heroica
Right: Philosopher's Codex, Bibliotheca Corvinaria

There was a recent exhibition in Budapest celebrating the 500th anniversary of Matthias or Mátyás Király's reign at which many of these were shown which justifiably attracted a lot of interest and tourism to the country.

The 1956 Uprising and its Aftermath

We had a meeting in the assembly hall of the Academy of Fine Arts, where students gave full vent to their views of the hated Social Realist style, describing it as petit bourgeois rubbish. It was, in fact, not unlike Victorian Kitsch. Unfortunately, it was difficult for us to find out about art movements outside of the Soviet bloc. Freedom of information simply did not exist. At the Academy, even the western fashion magazines were locked up or destroyed, as they might have influenced students by showing better living standards, glamorous clothes, or imaginative artwork.

The meeting was undoubtedly bugged.

Next day we heard the tragic news that the AVO had broken into the Academy and found one of my classmates Joska printing leaflets in the basement.

He was shot dead on the spot without questions or due process. The AVO was in effect totally outside the law.

Joska was printing the demands of the uprising, which were to be read out later at the radio station. These were broadly based on the objectives of the tragically defeated 1848 Hungarian Revolution, which demanded independence from the Austro-Hungarian Empire. The Czarist Russian troops were called in and slaughtered the ill-equipped few idealists who fought for their country, amongst them our national poet Sándor Petőfi⁴⁰, who fell in the battle of Segesvár in 1849, killed by a Russian lancer.

The main points of the demands were:

- The immediate evacuation of the Soviet troops
- An independent government to be set up under the leadership of Imre Nagy⁴¹

⁴⁰ Sándor Petőfi (1823–1849) is considered Hungary's national poet. A key figure of the Hungarian Revolution of 1848, he wrote the *Nemzeti dal* (National Song), which is said to have inspired the war for independence from the Austrian Empire. He probably died in battle during this war

⁴¹ Imre Nagy (1896–1958) served as Prime Minister and Chairman of the Council of Ministers of the Hungarian People's Republic from 1953 to 1956. He then became leader of the Hungarian Revolution of 1956 against the Soviet-backed government, for which he was executed in June 1958



Hole in the national flag, Budapest, 1956

- The right to market Hungary's uranium deposits
Actually these had already been removed and taken to the Soviet Union)
- The right of workers to strike
- The release and rehabilitation of the innocent political prisoners held in prisons and foreign concentration camps, the notorious gulags
- Complete recognition of freedom of expression of the press and radio
- Demand for a minimum wage for workers
- Immediate removal of the Stalin sculpture
- A Declaration of solidarity with the workers and students of Poland.



A Russian tank on the street in Budapest, 1956

On the 23rd October, engineering students called for a march to the statue of Petöfi and they were joined by office workers and medical students who started walking down Rákóczi Boulevard, right in front of our house. They carried the Hungarian flag with the communist emblem, the hammer and sickle, in the centre. The idea occurred to one of the students to cut out the hated symbol and so all the flags were mutilated and were carried forth with holes in the middle.

Young workers from the Isle of Csepel, an industrial area south of Budapest, were also heading towards the march, bringing guns and ammunition. These were not used and the march proceeded peacefully towards the radio station, where they disarmed the guards and managed to broadcast the aims and demands of the uprising.

After marching to the statue of our great national poet Petöfi, the crowd turned to the hated symbol of oppression, the monumental bronze sculpture of Stalin erected in 1951 to mark Stalin's 70th birthday. It had to be pulled down!

This was no easy task, as it was very well made, with steel reinforcement. Soon the welders disappeared and came back with oxyacetylene cutting gear and angle grinders. Little by little the statue began to keel over as it was pulled by sturdy ropes attached to the neck. Finally, the body fell to the ground amid shouts of joy and jubilation; only the bronze boots remained, into which a

Hungarian flag was planted. The statue has now been replaced by a modern abstract monument that commemorates the Uprising though the Hungarian government spent €100,000 on the severed bronze ear of the original statue, which is now kept in a museum.

A new democratic government was declared on the 28th October with Imre Nagy at its helm. Janos Kadar⁴² was also included as head of the newly reformed Communist Party. He had previously been tortured by the AVO and was therefore trusted when he swore loyalty to the government. The new regime tragically lasted just two weeks.

<https://youtu.be/bE1FXoUfo1I> Battle of Budapest Pathe News

Unfortunately, a few guns and primitive home-made weapons were no match for the returning Soviet forces, who invaded on 4th November. The resistance held out until 10th November, with some 2500 Hungarians killed in fighting. The new Soviet-installed government was led by Janos Kadar whilst Imre Nagy was arrested despite being promised safe passage out of the country. He was executed in 1958.

For a brief period, while the Russian army was occupied with putting down the uprising and securing key buildings and amenities, the borders were relatively unguarded.

Virtually everyone I knew fled the country. Friends rang up daily saying goodbye, in coded terms of course, as phones were bugged on a regular basis. Apart from boyfriend Sándor and my father, who, was, at 63, too old to leave, all my friends and their parents left. In all, some 200,000 people fled the country.

Petőfi, found and lost

In the period leading up to the Uprising, I had been involved in an intense romantic entanglement with one of the stage design students from college, Sándor Lévai, who started to work next door to the Academy in the puppet theatre. This was a fairly ambitious experimental outfit receiving state subsidies. They used ideas from imaginative Czech and Russian puppeteers and cartoon film makers and adapted them for the stage. They had children's programs in the mornings, when whole schools and nurseries visited, and it was a delight to watch the children so animated. I too had been quite interested in puppetry when I had been at the Academy of Applied Arts and recently found an invitation to a

⁴² Janos Kadar (1912 – 1989) was a Hungarian communist leader who led the country from 1956 until his retirement in 1988

Sándor Lévai, a most remarkable looking man



shadow puppet show I had been involved in amongst my papers. I had also made a short film of this show with one of my friends.

In Japan and China and throughout the orient, the wayang puppet performance, which is in fact a giant projection area could be watched by man in full colour, but women could only watch the shadows in black and white from the other side of the screen.

The players or puppeteers are situated underneath, in the pit.

This was possibly the first show or film being designed by myself and a friend Maya Doros, later professor of psychology at University of Texas, a budding feminist, which was specially made for women in black and white. The rest is history.

Short as it undoubtedly was, it got favourable reviews in the press and encouraged me to approach the puppet theatre next doors to my college and met up with their designer Sandor Levai.

In the evening, they had a rather mild satirical program, which by western standards was rather toothless, but nevertheless aroused the suspicion and disapproval of the AVO who were housed opposite.

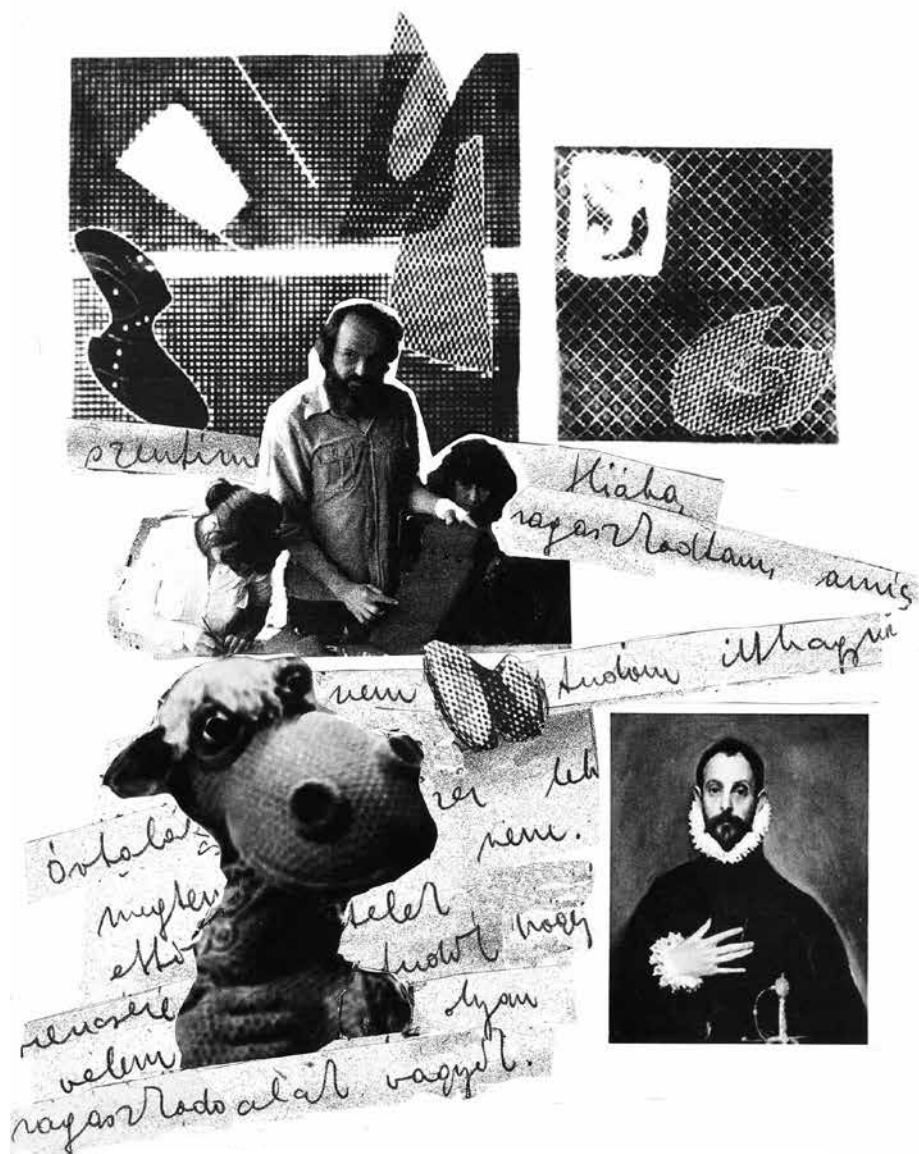
As well as designing the sets and costumes, Sándor helped out in most departments as they were short of hands and he was short of money.

He was a most remarkable looking young man; he looked exactly like El Greco's portrait of a knight, a young man with his hand on his chest, painted in the 1570s, and now in the Prado in Madrid.

Sándor also reminded people of Hungary's greatest poet and freedom fighter Sándor Petöfi. He took this superficial likeness very seriously and considered it almost an obligation to become an ardent patriot.

He was always dressed in a meticulously clean black corduroy suite, with a well-ironed open-neck white shirt. This was the only outfit he owned.

Every three months, he had to visit his parents in their small village near the Czech border to pay their carer and provide



when the strong were too weak to hurt the weak, the weak had to be strong enough to leave



Sándor Lévai, in later life

expenses for them. The journey took him three days.

His father was by then suffering from such severe dementia that he was unable to recognise his son; he thought he was a cat. The father had been a local judge and later an army officer in World War I. By the start of World War II he had retired, but the family had to leave their home when their area was allocated to Czechoslovakia in the Trianon Peace Treaty and they suffered extreme deprivations. His mother, 23 years younger than her husband, was very artistic.

We had but a few idyllic months together, before the Hungarian Uprising and resistance started to unfold. It was started mainly by students, who craved freedom of expression and a better future.

The Puppet Theatre was right next door to the Academy where my classmate Joska was shot in the basement whilst printing leaflets. There were no performances at the Puppet Theatre at the time, as by then most of the puppeteers decided to leave Budapest. Both the Communists and non-party members had decided to leave having successfully negotiated to start a puppet theatre in the annexe of the prestigious theatre in Győr a lively northern town. Most of the company had left by the time the uprising started, taking some of their designs and puppets with them. This move was expedited by the Director of the Puppet Theatre, a Communist who had been promoted to the job despite only having worked as a theatre hand. He irritated his colleagues by going around correcting their work and generally interfering with the artistic programme of the company.

It was by then too dangerous for me to make the trip to Győr, and telephones could be used only with the greatest precautions as everyone knew they were bugged.

We had discussed going to the West previously, but for Sándor it was impossible; he had to look after his parents. For me it was essential. I had to follow the revolution of the mind, more than anything else.

I had known for a while that we were all living a lie, living in a virtual prison of the mind and I had to free myself and start thinking afresh. I realized that Communism could not be improved upon or tinkered with; its shackles had to be thrown away altogether, relegated to history.

With hindsight, 60 years later my views are slowly becoming reality. The Soviet Union exists no longer, China is converting to Capitalism, Cuba received Pope Francis and President Obama and huge changes are in the pipeline; the only remaining communist countries are North Korea and Putin's Russia.

The decision to leave was traumatic and had a lasting influence on my life.

My telegram to Sandor from Vienna after my escape could not be delivered and it had to be read out on the phone. Sándor was in a shock and fell quite ill. I received two letters back from him, both from Győr; a short one after receiving the unexpected news of my departure and a telegram, which had to be read out on the phone for lack of other ways of communication at the time. A 14-page letter was inserted in a package brought out to the west by a friend, which I did not have the chance to read until recently, by which time he had been dead for 20 years.

In his long letter, Sándor tells me that he joined the Communist Party after the crushing of the 1956 uprising, not out of careerism, or opportunism, but out of conviction and patriotism and he got a new job in another theatre in Győr and a decent flat.

Recently, I have been in correspondence with the mother of one of his daughters. She never actually married him for the simple reason that she was already married to a famous poet and did not want a divorce. She was 19 years younger than Sándor and their relationship lasted until his untimely death. She still feels very romantic about him, saying that he was a good man, an idealist, who was somewhat politically naïve but incredibly generous and well intentioned.

He did marry two other women, many years apart, but these relationships did not work out. He had another daughter and a young son from these relationships. When he divorced his second wife, he negotiated the custody of his son Balázs, whom he brought up himself. Balázs was only 12 years old when he died and his mother was allowed to come back to stay in his flat to finish the job of bringing up their son.

In Győr, Sándor not only designed sets and puppets, but was also taken on for leading acting roles. After two years, the company decided to go back and re-join the Budapest Puppet Theatre, but found that the situation had not changed and that both the director and the remaining staff had sold out to the murderous Kadar regime, reneging on the ideals the theatre was founded on.

At this point, Sándor gave in his notice and left, which was an act punishable by imprisonment in Hungary. In this way, he made himself and his pregnant wife not only unemployed, but also unemployable.

Luckily, Children's television and films were being initiated by the state television company MTV and Sándor was asked to join in this work. He designed and in some cases produced some very

popular children's programs. These have in time become best sellers and the main money spinners for the company, having been translated into a number of languages. They have fan clubs all over the world. On my recent visit to Lanzarote, Spain, all the children and their families knew about Süss dragon, who keeps getting into trouble by trying to do good deeds. This rather daft, quite artless character made originally out of a sock, won the hearts and minds of people all over the world. Recently MTV had an offer from Walt Disney to make a feature film about Süss.

Sadly, by this point, Sándor was dead, having succumbed to lung cancer in 1997 at the age of 65. His designs were used without permission, so the three mothers of his children went to court to fight his case and quite unbelievably won. I find it quite touching how this odd family pulls together, meets up regularly and corresponds; these women all left Sándor as they were not compatible on the domestic level, but they still defend his reputation and are all besotted with him.

I understand that Sándor had a brilliant career but for me it would have been a huge mistake to stay just for him. When I began my research, I could not find much information about him.

Dragon SUSU on YouTube <https://youtu.be/y-IDggDUR7I>

I decided to investigate this discrepancy with my customary doggedness and after a lot of false starts and misinformation asked our ex-solicitor and former Rabbi John Reeves, who was going to Hungary, to ask around. Miraculously, I made contact with his son. Now 31, he seems the spitting image of his father near the age when I knew him, an almost disturbing likeness.

He is a great entrepreneur in the field of education, winning prizes and distinctions. I was absolutely thrilled to have made contact with him and we found out about our respective families. Balázs was keen to find information about his father as a young man and I about his later career as a successful professional. I was delighted about this and looking forward to future collaboration, when I received the greatest shock; in a discourteous and ruthless e-mail Balázs wrote to me that he is too busy with his work and getting so tired that he could no longer continue even intermittently with our correspondence. I was not only bitterly disappointed, but extremely sad.

This was surely not what his father would have liked. Sándor's 14-page letter, received in mysterious circumstances after many years was extremely generous and caring in spite of the great pain and shock my departure has caused him. Balázs's reason for

The struggle of men against power is a struggle of memory against forgetting



Köztársaság
 Készen állunk arra
 hogy minden polgár
 részvételével, minden a közösség
 érdekében és minden polgár
 a közösségért; egyenlőség mellett.
 Mindenki felelős azért hogy a
 közösség minden tagja
 jól érezze magát és
 mindenki számára
 legyen lehetőség arra
 hogy részt vegyen
 a közösségben.

snubbing me was, I think, personal as well as political. I was asking awkward questions about the present right-wing Orban regime as well as the previous Kadar regime. He was a young boy; this was before his time, although as an adult and young graduate he could have thought about it.

Kadar was catapulted into the country by the Soviet Union after the 1956 crushed uprising when the so-called “Goulash Communism” (*gulyáskommunizmus*) was set up. A certain amount of private enterprise was allowed and travel restrictions were eased. Free elections were not on the menu however and neither was freedom of the press.

The internationally known poet Illyés Gyula, who wrote *One Sentence on Tyranny* was not published for several years. He withdrew to the country, writing non-political work without compromising his integrity.

Unfortunately, as much as I was looking forward to meeting Balázs, and had invited him to our home and intended to introduce him to our family, I consider his behaviour towards me so rude that this is now impossible. I am greatly disappointed and saddened.

My Husband Gabor Sitkey

Although we met only briefly until we had both left our native Hungary for London, Gabor’s family history fits in well with the themes explored in this first volume of my memoirs so I share it here. Gabor comes from an impoverished branch of a noble family, whose history can be traced back to the 12th century. His father had a tailoring business; he never talked about his family to the children.

The story surfaced, when a Hungarian historian put in an advertisement into international newspapers looking for members of the Sitkey family. His brother Luin answered as he was going to Hungary anyway and received red carpet treatment in a village called Sitke which bears the family name. There was a magnificent mediaeval church and a castle, which was converted to a hotel, now called Castle Inn. The whole area belonged to Gabor’s ancestors who had many contacts, intermarriage and fights with the Esterházy family over many centuries.

Lacking a male heir, Gabor’s father’s generation became tradesmen; tailors, carpenters and undertakers. Gabor’s father, a tailor, married a girl, who had been adopted by a Christian family who had two sons, but could not have more children. They longed to have a daughter and adopted Gabor’s mother, who had been abandoned at birth and was briefly housed in an orphanage. His

mother was Jewish by birth.

The adoptive parents raised her with great care but she only went to school until she was 13 years old and then was taught domestic skills such as cooking, gardening and sewing. She must have been quite pretty too when Gabor's father married her.

He was a practical man and did not marry for money. In her, he had a skilled companion and manager of the household. He was a very popular man, friendly with everybody in the village. He gave speeches at weddings and funerals, played the cimbalom and the violin and helped out where he could.

In 1940, their new house and workshop was very near the main road along which German tanks rumbled all night heading towards Serbia and Italy. The first anti-Jewish laws had come out, so Gabor's father was very worried about his wife, whose birth certificate showed her origins.

Gabor's story continues in Volume 2.

One day he dropped in to visit his friend at the municipal record office, and sent him to the shop across the road for refreshments.

In the meantime, Gabor's father took out his wife's birth certificate and altered the dates with the official pen and ink so that his wife could no longer be identified.

Owing to this, she escaped persecution. She raised three children in very difficult circumstances and insisted that Gabor should be educated to the highest level.

Where she went wrong was that like Irene Schafer, whose husband ran an office from home, she tried to protect her husband from interruptions by a small child. She gave in easily to temper tantrums and uncontrollable fits of aggression.

All this receded into the background during the difficulties after the war and the struggle to get children to school from a remote village and then to the Academy of Applied Arts during the Soviet occupation.

During the uprising, Gabor took part in the demonstrations with all the other students and, fearing repercussions, he decided to escape together with another lad from the village. They took their bicycles with them and Gabor's father sewed a diamond ring into his heavy winter coat before they parted.

They were caught twice by the border patrols and arrested. They were eventually released because of their army record and, having left their bicycles behind, marched on foot through heavy terrain and hired a boat to take them over a river. By then they were so hot and exhausted, that Gabor thoughtlessly discarded his heavy coat forgetting about the valuable diamond ring sewn into it.

After being processed in a reception centre near Graz, they both ended up in England. Gabor was welcomed and housed by a wonderful English family in Cambridge for several months before leaving to join a course in Manchester College of Art, where he gained his diploma.

The Youngman family still remembered their wartime experience, when they sent their young son to a family in the USA to escape the heavy bombardment by the Luftwaffe. The family never accepted any payment or compensation. They felt a moral obligation to somehow pass on this gesture.

Gabor eventually graduated in Manchester College of Art and we met up again after my return from Paris. And so ended the darkest period of our lives and opened the window for a better, freer route to opportunities still not quite envisaged to absorb and understand the world.